Critical Reflection: *Lollis and McKenzie (2025)*

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Dobson and Lollis in their article, *I'm Coming Out!*, argue that LGBTQ lawmakers, especially those that are out, are more effective, and attribute this to discrimination creating electoral pressure that makes them work harder. They argue that electoral accountability translates voter discrimination into increased legislative efforts, as voters would be more likely to punish LGBTQ officials based on performance. Their argument assumes that voters observe and respond to legislative effectiveness. However, research on voter decision-making shows that voters rely on party identification, identity cues, and limited political information rather than evaluated performance. As a result, Dobson and Lollis's proposed voter-driven mechanism is not backed by theories and research of voter decision making.

Dobson and Lollis propose two mechanisms: a selection mechanism and a behavioral mechanism. The selection mechanism is based on electoral discrimination, as voters penalize candidates based on their LGBTQ identity, and that barrier filters the candidate pool so that only high-quality LGBTQ candidates succeed. The behavioral mechanism relies on anticipatory voter accountability, as LGBTQ legislators change their behavior because of expected prejudice. For these mechanisms to work, voters must receive information about legislative effectiveness, evaluate that information and use that in their vote choice, and legislators must expect this response, working more efficiently. Both the selection and behavioral mechanisms rely on voters being able to observe and respond to legislative effectiveness.

In their study of LGBTQ candidates, Magni and Reynolds tested how discrimination shapes vote choice by asking respondents to pick between candidates with randomized traits. They found that voters across three countries were less likely to choose LGBTQ candidates with electability concerns as the driving factor for voters, followed by prejudice and identity cues (Magni & Reynolds 2021). Although voters were presented with characteristics like education and prior political experience, electability and identity-based heuristics influenced vote choice more than competence signals. Discrimination in this experiment operated both directly and through perceptions of viability. As a result, electoral incentives are more likely to reward signs of electability and identity position instead of legislative effectiveness, challenging Dobson and Lollis's assumption that voters evaluate legislative performance.

Even when voters are exposed to political information like legislative effectiveness, their decisions are structured by their party identification. Zaller's Receive-Accept-Sample (RAS) model explains how this affects vote choice: individuals first receive information; they accept this information if it aligns with their predispositions, and then they sample from that information when forming opinions. Zaller argues voters do not independently evaluate political information and instead use party cues to make decisions (1991). This means that even if voters were aware of legislative effectiveness, it would be filtered through their existing party attachments, so there would be no legislative accountability. In the case of most voters, legislative effectiveness plays even less of a role in vote choice, as most voters are unlikely to receive information about legislative activity and therefore cannot use that to evaluate candidates. Zallers's RAS model shows it is unlikely that electoral accountability impacts the effectiveness of LGBTQ lawmakers, as that would require information and neutral evaluation.

Taken together, voters lack information about legislative effectiveness, rely on heuristics like electability and party identification when making decisions. As a result, voters are unable to evaluate legislative performance and reward or punish lawmakers based on their evaluations. This undermines Dobson and Lollis's argument that discrimination produces more effective lawmakers through electoral pressure, as their explanation requires that voters observe and evaluate legislative effectiveness. Existing research on voter behavior and LGBTQ political discrimination shows that these conditions do not hold. To directly test the claim that discrimination produces more effective lawmakers as a result of electoral accountability, future research would need to assess whether voters are aware of legislative effectiveness and whether that information impacts their vote choice. The lack of evidence that voters observe and evaluate legislative performance means that discrimination electoral accountability cannot plausibly explain the effectiveness gap.

References

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